

ASSET REDUCTION

In 1976, *INDIA TODAY* wrote of Katy Mirza, an ex-Playboy bunny of awesome physical proportions, who was feuding with another starlet to land the female lead in the Hindi film, *007*. In 1978, Shobhaa De, then Kilachand, wrote in *Eyecatchers* of her "well-publicised operation to reduce her bustline by ten fulsome inches". Calling it Operation Bust, she said Mirza emerged "slimmer, lighter and with a big load off her chest". Making a clean breast of it, what?



“Sweetheart, I didn’t really try for the *Time* cover. These things just happen to me.”

« PARVEEN BABI, ACTOR, 1976

Babi, the Babe

Her famous comment made Parveen Babi instantly the coolest Bollywood babe there was. “Sweetheart, I didn’t really try for the *Time* cover. These things just happen to me,” she drawled in 1976 after *INDIA TODAY* noted her “well-publicised adventures with Danny and Kabir Bedi”. By 1989, she was a shadow of her former self, “cheeks puffed, hair scraggy, mind ravaged by trauma”. “She harangues about a megastar who has been conspiring to kill her and calls it the greatest story in the world.” It was a return sorrier than the vanishing.

HEMANT PITHWA

Serial King

Kabir Bedi was never far from the magazine’s famous last page, as much because of the Italian pirate he played, *Sandokan*, as his serial dating. In 1979, he had divorced Protima Bedi and set out to marry American fashion designer Susan Humphrey, calling it the “second turning point in my life”. He had many more, but in 1996, *INDIA TODAY* paused to consider his screen work as well, when he came to India to shoot a \$50-million Italian serial. Just as in 1981, it had snarkily noted his presence at St. Stephen’s college’s centenary celebrations.



PANKAJ NANGIA



Beauty Rajkumari



INDIA TODAY always had an eye for beauty. And no one was perhaps more beautiful than Leela Naidu. In 1979, we welcomed her return after a 10-year jaunt in Hong Kong and London with husband, writer Dom Moraes. She was “noticeably plumper with Indira Gandhi-like white streaks” but her charm was intact. In 1990, she returned to the screen again after a five-year gap, as an impoverished rajkumari in *Electric Moon*. She had to cut her long hair for the role, which she feared would upset her husband no end.

PRASHANT PANJIAR